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Thomas Koch, Nora Denner & Felix Coutandin

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A CEO but Also A Parent: How Strategic Communication of Private Information about the CEO Affects Perceptions of an Organization during A Crisis

Thomas Koch[a], Nora Denner[b], and Felix Coutandin[c]

[a]Professor of Communication Science at the Department of Communication, Johannes Gutenberg University Mainz, Mainz, Germany; [b]Research associate at the Department of Communication, Johannes Gutenberg University Mainz; [c]Master student at the Department of Communication, Johannes Gutenberg University Mainz

ABSTRACT

In strategic communication, there is a plethora of studies dealing with effective crisis communication. CEO communication is an important building block in strategic crisis communication because in times of organizational crisis, the CEO often becomes an organization's most important spokesperson. In this role, the leader of the organization has the opportunity to frame the organization's crisis response in a certain way. The present study examines whether sharing private information about the CEO with stakeholders in a crisis response is beneficial for the perception of the organization. We experimentally analyze the effects of including such private information in a crisis response and test whether crisis type (accidental vs. preventable crisis) moderates these effects. The results show that organizational image is assessed more positively when the CEO includes private information in their crisis response. This effect is due to an increased identification with the CEO that, in turn, increases empathy for and trust in the CEO.

In 2007, Mattel, the world's largest toy company, faced a major crisis when they had to recall 18.2 million toys that contained small, high-powered magnets that could harm children if swallowed. The company also had to recall 436,000 toy cars because they were covered with lead paint (Story & Barboza, 2007). At the height of the crisis, Mattel published a full-page advertisement in multiple newspapers signed by CEO Bob Eckert, who addressed his "dear fellow parents," stating that, "as a father of four, I share your focus on providing only what's best for them," explaining that Mattel had voluntarily recalled the toys, and expressing his commitment to address all concerns (Rothlin & McCann, 2016, p. 115).

This example relates to three different elements that are important for dealing with crises. First, the case shows how crises can negatively affect an organization's reputation and long-term performance (Choi & Lin, 2009; Crijns, Cauberghe et al., 2017; Tkalac Verčič et al., 2019). Therefore, organizations must treat crises as serious threats and apply effective crisis management strategies (Barton, 2001; Coombs & Holladay, 2006). In this situation, as the Mattel case demonstrates, communication is crucial: Appropriate crisis response strategies can help to protect the reputation of an organization (Coombs, 2007; Coombs & Holladay, 2002). From a strategic communication point of view, crises are high-risk situations that drive strategic complexity. Therefore, crisis communication is an important part of strategic communication (Zerfass et al., 2018).

Second, the Mattel example illustrates how, in severe crises, organizations often personalize their communication and choose the CEO as a spokesperson to demonstrate that the handling of the crisis is a high priority (Balmas & Sheafer, 2013; Brettschneider & Vollbracht, 2011; Denner et al., 2021, 2019).

CONTACT Thomas Koch thomas.koch@uni-mainz.de Professor of Communication Science at the Department of Communication, Johannes Gutenberg University Mainz, Jakob-Welder-Weg 12, 55099 Mainz, Germany

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Many studies analyze the effects of different crisis response strategies (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2008; Coombs et al., 2016; Crijns, Claeys et al., 2017; Dutta & Pullig, 2011; Verhoeven et al., 2012), but there is a lack of research on the source of organizational communication in crises and how this source affects stakeholders' perceptions. The choice of who should communicate with the public is an important matter for strategic communication because a crisis is an uncertain and complex event (Nothhaft et al., 2018), and the outcome of public statements is unclear (Zerfass et al., 2018). Consequently, this decision can benefit or harm public perception of the organization (Allen & Caillouet, 1994; Arpan, 2002; Benoit, 1997; Coombs, 1998, 1999; Tkalac Verčič et al., 2019). Previous research shows that personalized statements made by an executive have a more favorable impact on organizational image compared with "unpersonalized" statements, in which the organization itself is the source, especially if the statement is made by the CEO of the organization (Denner et al., 2019).

Third, the Mattel case demonstrates how personalized communication can be complemented by the personal or private characteristics of an organizational executive. Eckert addressed stakeholders "as a father of four" and stated that "your children are our children, too" (Rothlin & McCann, 2016). Presumably, he mentioned this private information about himself in his crisis response to allow stakeholders to identify with him, which could strengthen empathy for him and build trust in him individually and consequently positively affect perceptions of the company. This article examines whether this strategy pays off for an organization in crisis. Building on crisis communication research and the concept of privatization, we experimentally investigate the effects of receiving private information about a CEO on perceptions of an organization's image. We also consider the potential mediating effects of empathy for and trust in the CEO and investigate whether crisis type (accidental vs. preventable crisis) moderates the effects.

Organizational crises and crisis communication

A crisis can be defined as "the perception of an unpredictable event that threatens important expectancies of stakeholders and can seriously impact an organization's performance and generate negative outcomes" (Coombs, 2015, p. 2). To manage a crisis effectively, organizations need to be prepared to always respond to crises (Gribas et al., 2018; Heath, 2010). Organizational crisis management comprises a "set of factors designed to combat crises and to lessen the actual damage inflicted" (Coombs, 2015, p. 21). By carrying out effective crisis management, organizations can protect their reputation and even improve it (Benoit, 1997; Coombs, 2010).

Organizations may choose from a range of communication strategies to limit potential damage to their reputation (Benoit & Pang, 2008; Coombs, 2007, 2010). One of the most widely applied approaches for dealing with crises through communication is Coombs's (2007) situational crisis communication theory (SCCT). Based on attribution theory (Weiner, 1986), SCCT links the crisis situation to specific crisis management strategies intended to protect the organization's reputation. Attribution theory assumes that people try to determine why other individuals do what they do; hence, people also aim to analyze the causes of a particular crisis situation and decide to whom they should attribute blame (Weiner, 1986). The SCCT suggests a two-step process for selecting an appropriate strategy to react to such attributions because they can play a key role in shaping perceptions of organizational reputation as well as stakeholders' emotions and behaviors (Coombs, 2010). First, the extent to which the stakeholders hold the organization accountable for the incident is identified. Second, the organization's crisis history and reputation are evaluated because these two factors impact how stakeholders attribute responsibility (Coombs, 2010).

The SCCT offers a systematization of crisis accountability and divides crisis types into three clusters: victim crises, characterized by weak attribution of responsibility, accidental crises, with low or moderate attribution of responsibility, and preventable crises, with very strong attribution of responsibility (Coombs, 2007). Examples of crises where the organization itself is the victim are rumors, natural disasters, and other external events that damage the organization. The accidental cluster includes crises in which the organization's actions leading to the crisis are unintentional, such

as technical errors that cause a malfunction or result in a product being recalled. If an organization knowingly places people at risk, takes inappropriate actions, or violates laws or regulations, the crisis can be assigned to the preventable cluster (Coombs, 2007; Coombs & Holladay, 2001). The appropriate crisis response strategy is then selected based on the crisis type as well as the crisis history and prior reputation of the organization.

During a crisis, a spokesperson will often make an official statement to relevant stakeholders containing the crisis response strategy (Tkalac Verčič et al., 2019). Although previous research recognizes the importance of a credible spokesperson in a crisis (Coombs, 1999, 2015), other source characteristics remain underexamined (Arpan, 2002; Tkalac Verčič et al., 2019). However, these characteristics may have an impact on what stakeholders think of the crisis situation. Applied to crisis communication, source effects, defined as the characteristics of the spokesperson, may impact what the audience believes about the crisis situation (Arpan, 2002).

Spokespeople are often public relations professionals, but the CEO of an organization can also act as a spokesperson. Especially when an organization is facing a severe crisis, the CEO is often chosen as a spokesperson to demonstrate that the organization is taking the crisis seriously (Laufer et al., 2018; Seeger & Ulmer, 2001). Additionally, the management of the crisis is perceived as more appropriate if a leader is involved in external crisis communication (Denner et al., 2019), particularly in situations where the integrity or reputation of an organization is at stake (Lucero et al., 2009; Schoofs & Claeys, 2021). How stakeholders perceive the CEO (and the CEO's actions) affects their perceptions and evaluations of the company (Pollach & Kerbler, 2011; Schoofs & Claeys, 2021) because there is a strong link between organizational and CEO reputation (Alsop, 2004; Gaines-Ross, 2000).

Previous research has examined the effects of different sources of crisis communication (e.g., the CEO as a spokesperson; Denner et al., 2019; Tkalac Verčič et al., 2019), but there has been little work investigating the effects of source characteristics on personal and organizational reputation. Scholars have analyzed the influence of nonverbal cues, e.g., visual, verbal, and vocal characteristics (e.g., Claeys & Cauberghe, 2014; Gorn et al., 2008; De Waele et al., 2017, 2018; De Waele, Claeys et al., 2020; De Waele, Schoofs et al., 2020), or of gender and gender similarity (e.g., Crijns, Claeys, et al., 2017a; Kapuścińsk et al., 2021; Kulczynski et al., 2021) on perceptions of spokespeople, but, to our knowledge, no attention has been paid to private information about the CEO as a form of personalization or how such information can support the chosen crisis response strategy of an organization in crisis.

Personalization and privatization

When organizations put their leaders up front or the media explicitly focus on the CEO and their personality instead of the organization itself, there is a strong focus on individuals. This is known as personalization (Van Aelst et al., 2012). Information related to CEOs' private lives lies within the realm of *privatization*, one of two subdimensions of personalization (the other being *individualization*; Van Aelst et al., 2012). Individualization describes how individuals become a central focus of media coverage and organizations become less relevant, whereas privatization refers to the presentation of individuals in high-level positions as ordinary people (e.g., the presentation of a CEO as a nature-lover or a passionate home handyperson). According to Van Aelst et al. (2012) and Smith (2018), privatization involves a shift toward either individuals' personal traits (professional/non-professional traits) or the personal lives of leaders (private lives and personal interests), such as a leader's family life, hobbies, or love life.

The potential influence of personal information (e.g., information about someone's private life) may be explained through the Common Ingroup Identity Model (CIIM; Gaertner & Dovidio, 2012), "a social categorization-based perspective for reducing intergroup bias and improving intergroup relations" (Gaertner & Dovidio, 2012, p. 439). The basic features of the CIIM are based on the assumptions of social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) and the related self-categorization theory (Turner et al., 1987), which posit that people have a natural tendency to identify themselves and others using social categories and to assign themselves to groups (i.e., as ingroup vs. outgroup members).

Based on the CIIM, we hypothesize that private information can function as a salient cue for the perception of membership similarity and can therefore lead to a common identity between the CEO and the recipient (ingroup perception). If the CEO is perceived as similar because of private information known about them and is understood to be a member of the ingroup, this can evoke identification with the CEO (Caspers, 2019; Einwiller et al., 2017). Moreover, psychological research shows that individuals who feel properly understood and valued by a (personally unknown) person feel connected and/or close to this person (e.g., Cross et al., 2000; Morelli et al., 2014; Reis et al., 2017). We therefore introduce our first hypothesis (Figure 1):

H1: Disclosing private information about a CEO increases identification with the CEO.

Crijns, Claeys et al. (2017) found that membership similarity in the context of a preventable crisis leads to stakeholders having higher levels of empathy for a spokesperson. According to the authors, this connection arises from a perceived bond between the stakeholders and the spokesperson, in their case based on sharing the same gender. Ingroup identification also leads to more trust in a person (Voci, 2006), including in a crisis context (Arpan, 2002). Tkalac Verčič et al. (2019) argue that trust is a relevant factor when choosing the right spokesperson in a crisis situation and that the CEO can have an especially positive effect because of their leadership position. Einwiller et al. (2017) found a positive correlation between stakeholders' identification with a CEO and the perceived credibility of the CEO's crisis statement, which, in turn, could lead to an increase in the CEO's perceived trustworthiness. We therefore introduce the following hypotheses (Figure 1):

H2a: Identification with the CEO increases perceived empathy for the CEO.

H3a: Identification with the CEO increases trust in the CEO.

As mentioned above, there is a strong connection between organizational reputation and the personal reputation of the CEO. Consequently, the organizational image and the personal image of the CEO are also strongly intertwined. This is because of image transfer effects, which arise from the attribution of shared characteristics to the CEO and the organization by the stakeholders (Caspers, 2019). The CEO and the organization form one unit in terms of stakeholder perceptions; therefore, stakeholders automatically transfer the characteristics of the CEO to the organization. Caspers (2019) argues that these image transfer effects are caused by the fact that personal characteristics are more easily perceptible compared with the characteristics of an abstract organization, which also relates to the ability of personalization to reduce complexity (Balmas & Sheafer, 2013; Brettschneider & Vollbracht, 2011).

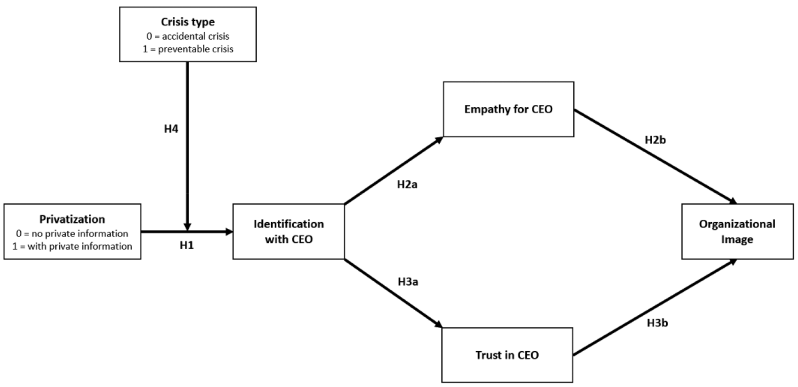


Figure 1. Conceptual model of research.

Regarding image transfer effects in a crisis context, Crijns, Claeys, et al. (2017a) found a positive connection between perceived empathy for a spokesperson and perceptions of their organization in the context of a preventable crisis. Schoofs et al. (2019) also found a positive effect of perceived empathy for a CEO on perceptions of their organization. Therefore, trust in and empathy for a CEO may lead to a positive perception of their organization, as expressed in the following hypotheses (Figure 1):

H2b: Perceived empathy for the CEO improves the perceived organizational image.

H3b: Perceived trust in the CEO improves the perceived organizational image.

In an organizational crisis, crisis type may moderate the relationship between privatization and identification with the CEO. In the context of a preventable crisis, which is associated with high attribution of responsibility, membership similarity to the CEO may be irrelevant to stakeholders (König et al., 2020; Roccas & Brewer, 2002) because a moral or ethical standard may instead represent the central basis for the ingroup–outgroup distinction, with the stakeholders perceiving the CEO, as the responsible organizational representative, to be part of an outgroup (outgroup: guilty/responsible organization vs. ingroup: innocent/affected stakeholders).

If a crisis is associated with moderate or low attribution of responsibility, as in the case of an accidental crisis, membership similarity may be more important to the stakeholders. This idea leads to the hypothesis that the relationship between private CEO communication and identification with the CEO depends on the type of crisis (Figure 1):

H4: Crisis type (accidental crisis vs. preventable crisis) moderates the influence of privatization on identification with the CEO.

Method

Sample

We recruited 235 subjects (62.1% female; M_{age} = 34.4 years, SD_{age} = 12.7 years) via social media. Participation was voluntary and unpaid.

Design and Procedure

We used a 2 × 2 between-subjects factorial design and manipulated the amount of private information in a CEO's crisis response (factor 1: no private information vs. private information included) and the crisis type (factor 2: preventable crisis vs. accidental crisis). Subjects were randomly assigned to one of the four experimental conditions. We asked the participants to read an online news article that reported on an ongoing crisis at a fictitious company ("EURO Cosmetics AG") and to complete a questionnaire after they finished reading.

Stimuli

The news article informed readers about a product recall of a toothpaste for children. The product recall was because of microbial contamination, which can cause burning inside of the mouth. This crisis scenario was chosen because it could be used to represent both a preventable crisis and an accidental crisis with a few changes to the article. In the variations of the article, the contamination was caused either by maintenance work carried out by an external contractor (accidental crisis) or by inadequate hygiene standards because of cost savings efforts (preventable crisis). Each of the four

article variants quoted a statement from EURO Cosmetics AG's CEO, Thomas Reuter, in response to the crisis. He apologized to the affected children and their parents. He also provided assurances that a comprehensive analysis of the incident would be carried out, emphasizing that the situation was being taken very seriously and that the circulation of the toothpaste had been stopped for the time being. The second experimental factor we manipulated was whether the CEO mentioned private information in his crisis response. The response either did not include any private information or the CEO stated "I understand how you feel. I myself have a four-year-old daughter and a six-year-old son. Especially as a family man, I really take the situation very seriously. My daughter had to deal with an allergic reaction last year, and, as a father, I know about the worry this causes."

Measures

The measures of all constructs in our conceptual model of research were based on previous literature. We measured the *organization's image* using a five-point semantic differential scale of six adjective pairs in response to the item "I believe that EURO Cosmetics AG is . . . " (Koch et al., 2019). Three items measured the cognitive image dimension (Crites et al., 1994; Eagly et al., 1992): "incompetent–competent," "unprofessional–professional," and "not capable–capable." The other three adjective pairs referred to the affective image dimension: "not friendly–friendly," "not likeable–likeable," and "not genuine–genuine." The items were combined into an index, $M = 3.19$, $SD = 0.26$, $\alpha = .85$.

To assess *identification with the CEO*, we used a five-point Likert scale (ranging from *strongly disagree* to *strongly agree*) to gauge responses to four items similar to those introduced by Einwiller et al. (2017; based on Basil, 1996): "I like Thomas Reuter," "I can easily relate to Thomas Reuter," "I think it would be pleasant to work in a company where Thomas Reuter was the CEO," and "Thomas Reuter and I share similar values." We created an index of the four items, $M = 2.99$, $SD = 0.76$, $\alpha = .79$.

To assess *trust in the CEO*, we asked the subjects to rate the extent of their agreement with the following five statements on a five-point Likert scale (ranging from *strongly disagree* to *strongly agree*): "Thomas Reuter is concerned with the well-being of his company's customers," "Thomas Reuter is basically honest," "I do not trust Thomas Reuter to tell the truth about the incident" (reverse coded), "Under most circumstances, I would be likely to believe what Thomas Reuter says," and "Thomas Reuter acted responsibly in the situation." These five items are based on the scale of Einwiller et al. (2017); see also, Coombs & Holladay, 1996, Coombs & Holladay (2002). We constructed an index of the five variables, $M = 3.46$, $SD = 0.70$, $\alpha = .81$.

Finally, we measured *empathy for the CEO* using five items of a scale used by McCullough et al. (2003) and by Coke et al. (1978). This scale has also been used by Crijns, Claeys, et al. (2017a) and Schoofs et al. (2019) in the context of crisis communication. We asked the participants to rate the extent of their agreement with five items on a five-point Likert scale (ranging from *strongly disagree* to *strongly agree*). The subjects responded to these items to indicate how much they currently felt each of the following feelings regarding the CEO: sympathetic, empathic, concerned, moved, and compassionate, $M = 2.73$, $SD = 0.74$, $\alpha = .78$.

As a manipulation check, we assessed the attribution of responsibility for the crisis using Griffin et al.'s (1992) scale for blame. We asked the subjects to use a five-point Likert scale (ranging from *strongly disagree* to *strongly agree*) to assess the extent of their agreement with the following two items: "Circumstances, not the organization, are responsible for the crisis" (reverse coded) and "The blame for the crisis lies with the organization," $M = 3.68$, $SD = 1.10$, $\alpha = .87$.

Treatment check

An independent samples *t*-test demonstrated that the subjects perceived the company to have a higher degree of responsibility after reading the preventable crisis version of the article ($M = 4.30$, $SD = 0.76$) than after reading about the accidental crisis scenario ($M = 3.08$, $SD = 1.04$), $t(233) = 10.19$, $p < .001$. Moreover, we checked whether the manipulation of the second experimental factor (private

information) worked sufficiently. We asked the participants whether the CEO mentioned his children. A cross tabulation showed that 97.4% of those in the condition with private information vs. 97.5% in the condition without private information answered this question correctly, $\chi^2(1, n = 235) = 211.59$, $p < .001$. Hence, our manipulation of both factors was successful.

Results

Since we are interested in how crisis type moderates the effect of privatization on identification and how empathy as well as trust mediate the effect of identification on organizational image, we conducted a moderated mediation analysis. For our analysis, we used Hayes's (2018) ordinary least squares regression-based PROCESS path analysis program (Version 3.5 for SPSS). Regression coefficients reported below are unstandardized. Whether the CEO included private information in his crisis response was the independent variable (0 = no private information, 1 = private information included) and the organization's image served as dependent variable. The hypotheses were tested with the help of a specially built model with three mediators and one moderator. A mediator explains the process through which two variables, in this case privatization and organizational image, are related. The three mediators in our model were identification with the CEO, empathy for the CEO, and trust in the CEO. A moderator affects the strength and direction of the relationship between variables. In our model, crisis type served as moderator variable (0 = accidental crisis, 1 = preventable crisis) of the relationship between privatization and identification with the CEO. The results of this analysis are reported in Figure 2. The model was run with 5,000 bootstrap samples.

The analysis shows that including private information in the CEO's crisis response significantly increases identification with the CEO, $b = .54$, $p < .001$, confirming H1. An unstandardized b of .54 means that if private information is included, identification increases by approx. .54 on the five-point Likert scale. Identification with the CEO, in turn, increases empathy for the CEO, $b = .73$, $p < .001$, as well as trust in the CEO, $b = .72$, $p < .001$, confirming H2a and H3a. Both empathy for the CEO and trust in the CEO lead to more positive perceptions of the organizational image, $b = .18$, $p < .01$ vs. $b = .19$, $p < .05$, as predicted in H2b and H3b. The mediation analysis shows that including private information in the CEO's crisis response had three significant indirect effects on perceptions of organizational image. The first indirect effect is mediated by identification with the CEO and empathy

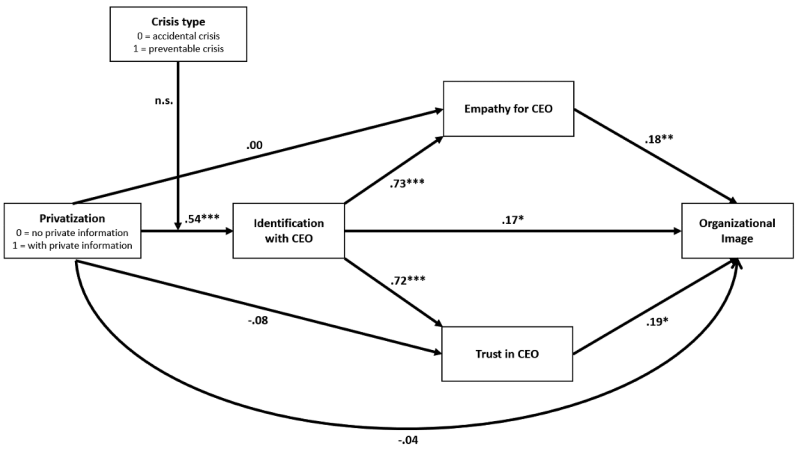


Figure 2. Results of the moderated mediation analysis.
Note. The numbers presented are unstandardized path coefficients.
*$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$

for the CEO, $b = .07$, 95% CI [.02, .14]. The second indirect effect is mediated by identification with the CEO and trust in the CEO, $b = .07$, 95% CI [.01, .15]. Finally, the third significant indirect effect is mediated only by identification with the CEO, $b = .09$, 95% CI [.01, .21]. Taken together, these findings show that including private information about a CEO in a crisis response has a significant positive total effect on perceptions of organizational image, $b = .19$, $p < .05$.

We also tested whether crisis type moderates the effect of including private information on identification with the CEO. The analysis shows that the proposed moderation effect is not significant, $p < .05$. Hence, there is no support for H4. However, there is a main effect of crisis type on organizational image, $F(3, 231) = 17.23$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = .07$, showing that participants perceive the organizational image more positively in the accidental crisis scenario ($M = 3.03$, $SD = 0.61$) compared with the preventable crisis scenario ($M = 3.35$, $SD = 0.60$).

Discussion

In times of crisis, appropriate communication is crucial as it helps to protect a company's reputation. Research has demonstrated that it can be essential who communicates with the public and that personalized statements made by the company's CEO have a more favorable impact compared with "unpersonalized" statements. The present study was going one step further and examined the effects of privatized crisis communication on recipients' perceptions of an organization. Therefore, we conducted a 2 × 2 online experiment and varied crisis type (accidental vs. preventable crisis) as well as the amount of private information in a CEO's crisis response (no private information vs. private information). We created a moderated mediation model with privatization as independent variable, crisis type as moderator, and identification with the CEO, empathy for the CEO and trust in the CEO as mediators (see, Figure 2). Organizational image served as dependent variable. Since we find a significant, positive total effect of our model, we can conclude that organizational image is assessed more positively when the crisis communication contains private information about the CEO than when it does not contain such information. The effect is not based on a direct effect of privatization on organizational image but arises from the mediators, namely identification with the CEO, empathy for the CEO and trust in the CEO: If a statement contains private information, the identification with the CEO is higher, which, in turn, has a positive effect on both empathy for and trust in the CEO. Furthermore, empathy for and trust in the CEO both increase the perceived organizational image. Consequently, three significant indirect effects on perceptions of organizational image emerge from the analysis.

However, we found no moderating effect of crisis type on the effect of privatization on identification with the CEO. This means that the observed effect of privatization is independent from the crisis type. Thus, privatized statements by a CEO can positively enhance public's perception of the organization and may help an organization in crisis to maintain its image, regardless of the crisis type. Our findings support the idea that personalized crisis statements – and especially privatized statements – are useful as a strategic tool in crisis communication.

The introduction of this article asked whether this strategy pays off for an organization in crisis and the study suggests that it does: Communicating private information about a CEO can be a useful strategy in crisis communication as stakeholders can more easily identify with the CEO. A key mechanism here could be that recipients perceive the CEO not only in his function as an organizational executive or manager but also as person (a CEO but also a Parent). Thus, mentioning private information in a crisis response affects recipients' perception of the speaker and, in turn, the perception of the organization.

Of course, this study has several limitations. First, our experiment focused on one specific aspect of privatization, being a parent. We can therefore only draw conclusions concerning this particular aspect. No inferences can be drawn concerning how the individualization dimension or aspects of privatization other than being a parent affect perception of an organization in crisis. Other scenarios might alter the

effects reported here and should therefore be explored in future research. For example, different forms of privatization in a crisis context could be explored. Furthermore, we did not test all crisis clusters elaborated by Coombs (2007); rather, we focused only on preventable and accidental crises.

Second, we chose a male CEO for our study. Although the appearance of a male CEO in public corporate statements is very common and externally valid, the findings do not necessarily apply to female CEOs or other types of public speakers. Future studies should test whether the use of different representatives leads to different results, examining, for example, whether there is a "punishment effect" for women like that found in the political arena (Bell & Kaufmann, 2005; Stalsburg, 2010).

A third limitation is the artificial nature of the experiment that diminishes the external validity of the reported findings. The study focused on a very specific type of crisis, a specific crisis response strategy (the CEO apologized and provided assurances that the situation was being taken very seriously and an analysis of the incident would be carried out), as well as on a very specific type of organization (a company in the cosmetics and personal care industry). Moreover, our study used a fictitious organization, a fictitious CEO and we were not dealing with an actual crisis but developed a fictitious scenario (recall of a toothpaste for children because of microbial contamination). This was all helpful to ensure that recipients did not have any preexisting attitudes towards the organization, the crisis, or the CEO. However, this advantage comes with a disadvantage: It is unclear to what extent the findings can be generalized to real-life settings and transferred to other contexts. Therefore, more studies are needed in the contexts of actual crisis scenarios.

A fourth limitation concerns the variables included in our model. The focus on identification with the CEO, trust in the CEO, as well as empathy for the CEO represents only a part of the cognitive and affective processes that are important in the crisis communication context. Other mediating constructs such as authenticity, persuasion knowledge, or reactance should be considered in future research. The same applies to the dependent variable: We focused on organizational image as dependent variable. However, organizational reputation, trust in the organization, or perception of the crisis communication could also be considered in future studies. Finally, experimental designs cannot consider the long-term image-building process when measuring attitudes. For example, we measured the perceived image directly after the reception of a single stimulus representing a fictitious scenario. Thus, the subjects' perceptions were based on a single exposure. These limitations could be addressed by using research designs that include multiple measurement points and/or several exposures.

Conclusions

This study adds to the existing research suggesting the involvement of CEOs in organizational crisis response benefits the organization (e.g., Denner et al., 2019; Lucero et al., 2009; Ulmer et al., 2011; Van Slyke Turk et al., 2012). Information about the CEO's private life as a form of personalization could help organizations establish a relationship between the cause (in this case, a crisis) and a responsible or affected person (Denner et al., 2018, 2021), which may lead to better perceptions not only of the CEO but also of the organization.

However, it may be important that the private information is related to the crisis – the information should be relevant in the context of the organizational crisis (Simons et al., 1970). In our study, the CEO himself was a parent and could therefore understand the customers' worries regarding the children's toothpaste. If irrelevant or out-of-place information about the CEO's private life were included in the crisis response, the effect might be absent, and a backfire effect could occur. However, we did not test this idea, and we suggest that future studies examine whether this is indeed the case.

The effect might also depend on the crisis context. We hypothesized that the effect might be moderated by crisis type because the public might respond differently in cases where the CEO knowingly took inappropriate action or violated regulations compared with cases where the crisis was caused unintentionally. However, the results show that the type of crisis did not moderate the effect. Nevertheless, there could be other contextual factors that play a role. The SCCT suggests that crisis history and prior organizational reputation, for example, should be considered when choosing

a crisis response strategy; therefore, these factors could be important in determining the effect of private information about the CEO on perceptions regarding the CEO and the organization. Additionally, characteristics of the CEO (e.g., prior reputation, gender, or appearance) could be relevant (Coombs, 2010; Ulmer et al., 2011). Future studies should experimentally test whether such additional factors are influential. Another explanation might be that the crisis was not severe enough to cause effects. The toothpaste was recalled because it can cause burning inside of the mouth, which is unpleasant, but not life threatening. A more severe crisis, either preventable or accidental, might have had clearer moderating effects on the effect of privatization on identification with the CEO.

For strategic communication practitioners our results can be helpful to position the CEO in a crisis scenario. For a sensible use of the CEO's private life, they have to understand the strengths and weaknesses of their CEO. Of course, private statements always need the approval of the leader in question, but possible crisis scenarios for the concerning organization can be anticipated and practiced. Furthermore, crisis training can also help to practice strategies and appearance in a crisis scenario. However, this does not always mean that organizations should use private information about the CEO no matter what.

The most important point to consider is how well the private information fits the crisis: The disclosed private information needs to be appropriate and suitable for the crisis scenario. It should offer a clear reference to the crisis to evoke identification. It also should make it possible to address stakeholders' emotions. In our case, the CEO understands that people are in fear of allergic reactions caused by the toothpaste, because he himself knows this fear. Private information can make the CEO appear as a "human like you and me," as an ordinary person. This mechanism is known from political communication research (Holtz-Bacha, 2004; Langer, 2010; Smith, 2018). A feeling of connectedness and similarity that privatization can evoke also supports the ingroup perception (Caspers, 2019; Einwiller et al., 2017).

However, research also suggests that excessive repetition can cause wear out effects and reduce the effectiveness of persuasive stimuli (Koch, 2017). Even worse, presenting this information too often can even cause recipients to perceive it as a persuasive attempt and trigger reactance (Koch & Zerback, 2013; Moyer-Gusé & Nabi, 2010). Therefore, it might be important that CEOs use the strategic communication of private information during a crisis in the proper doses.

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ORCID

Thomas Koch http://orcid.org/0000-0002-3495-5855

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